

EGERTON



UNIVERSITY

COMP 495 – SEMINAR PAPER

Course Instructor: DR GEORGE ODONGO

GUIDELINES FOR THE WRITING OF SEMINAR PAPERS

Seminar papers are scientific texts and are thus subject to certain requirements regarding format and content. The following paragraphs provide the most essential standards for the writing of seminar papers.

The seminar paper constitutes one out of three sub-requirements that have to be achieved in COMP 495.

Structuring the seminar paper

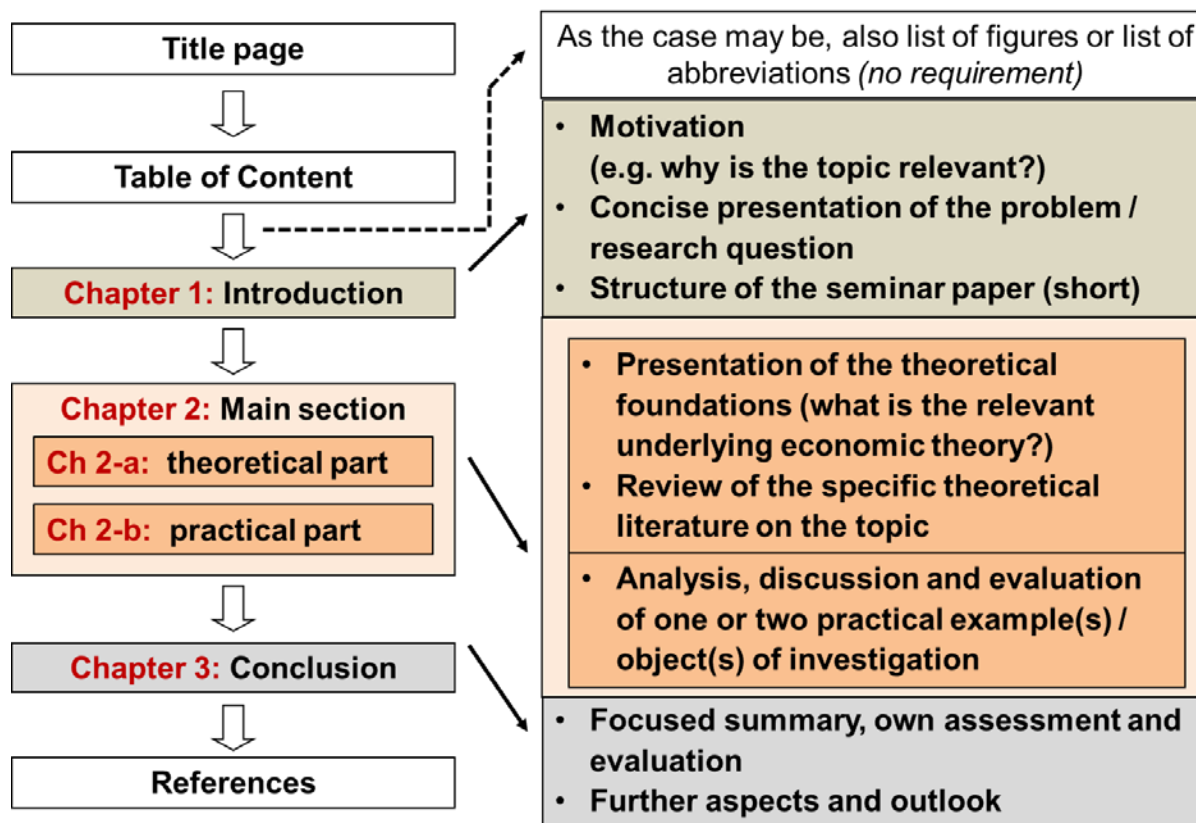
The seminar paper, including introduction, main section and concluding remarks **must not exceed 12 pages**. An appendix can only be added (after consultation with the instructor) if the topic requires the use of large-size figures and tables or comprehensive mathematical expositions.

Seminar papers have to have a clear structure. This implies that sections and subsections follow in a logical order and do not merely constitute a random enumeration of aspects relevant to the main topic. The paper has to be subdivided into paragraphs, sections and subsections. Employing sections and subsections only makes sense if sub-chapter 1.1 is, for example, followed by sub-chapter 1.2. Sections, which are shorter than one page should be avoided. When structuring your seminar paper, please make sure to include reader-friendly transitions to guide the reader from one section to the subsequent one.

The table of contents providing the deep structure has to be included directly after the title page. It has to contain page references for all paragraphs, sections and subsections, the headings of which have to be repeated at the respective locations in the text.

The introductory paragraph provides a first characterization of the topic. It answers the question why this topic is worth investigating and is concluded by an overview of the structure of the paper. In the subsequent paragraphs, firstly the theoretical foundations of the topic have to be displayed. This is usually done in the form of a review of the relevant literature in the respective field. After that, the specific topic (i.e. a case study or a specific economic or political issue) is dealt with and the results are discussed according to the criteria developed in the theoretical section. The last paragraph contains some concluding remarks. This part emphasizes and evaluates the main findings of the paper (avoid mere summaries!). The concluding remarks should also provide interesting perspectives for future research.

The structure of a seminar paper can be displayed in schematic form:



Writing the seminar paper

The scientific nature of a seminar paper is closely connected to the use of literature that has been published in the relevant field. Existing statements by other authors have to be quoted, controversial approaches have to be displayed and a position regarding their content has to be developed. Please note, however, that the literature review is (merely) of auxiliary nature and does not make up for an independent interpretation and analysis of the relevant economic issue.

Throughout the text, all direct and indirect quotations have to be clearly marked and corresponding references have to be indicated. A seminar paper lacking either a complete bibliography or references in the text will not be accepted. Please make sure to indicate all sources of any type of intellectual property. This also applies to all quoted numbers, tables and figures. The infringement of intellectual property rights by passing off ideas of others as one's own is a serious violation of the rules of scientific duty of documentation. Such plagiarism will be penalised. In addition, such plagiarism might infringe copyright law, which will potentially be prosecuted.

On a related note, please make sure to complete and sign the statutory declaration provided by the chair and attach it to the seminar paper as the last page. This form is also available on the website of the chair. Seminar papers lacking this declaration will not be accepted.

The use of existing literature

Quotations have to be made according to the APA Style of Referencing. According to this set of referencing guidelines, the source of a direct or indirect quotation has to be inserted in brackets just after the quotation. Footnotes shall not be used to indicate quotations but can be used to explain independent statements that add more information to the main text.

The following examples illustrate the above quotation rules:

- Direct quotations
 - “Life is hard” (Meier, 1993, p. 32).
- Indirect quotations
 - Meier (1993, p. 32) maintains that life is hard.
 - Some authors take the view that life is hard (Meier, 1993, p. 32).

The **bibliography** (also called “list of references”) must contain all references of the seminar paper. They must be ordered alphabetically. Do not list references which are not quoted in the text. The following examples might help to edit the bibliography:

- Carson, R. / Hanemann, M. (2005), Contingent valuation, in: Mäler, K.-G. / Vincent, J. (eds.) Hand- book of Environmental Economics, 821 - 936.
- Endres, A. (2011), Environmental Economics: Theory and Policy, Cambridge.
- Graham, D. A. (1992), Public expenditure under uncertainty: The net-benefit criteria, American Economic Review 82, 822 - 846.
- Samuelson, P. (1954), The pure theory of public expenditure, The Review of Economic Statistics 36, 387 - 389.
- Varian, H. (1992), Microeconomic analysis, 3rd edition, New York.

Quotations from the internet should only provide additional information in a seminar paper. The primary source of references should be the scientific literature relevant for the specific topic. As a consequence, the share of internet sources in the bibliography must not exceed 25 per cent.

Formatting of the text

When formatting the text of your seminar paper please pay attention to the following general rules:

- The seminar paper should neither exceed nor be less than 12 pages.

- Make sure you have sufficient page margins (left 2.5cm, right 2.0cm, top and bottom 2.5cm, respectively), correct line spacing (1.5-times) as well as a font of 12pt in font type New Times Roman or 11pt in font type Arial. In addition, the text should be put in full justification and auto-hyphenation should be activated.
- Footnotes have to be set in 10pt for both Times New Roman and Arial.
- Headings of paragraphs, sections and subsections have to be set in bold 14 points for Times New Roman or 12 points in Arial.
- Pages have to be numbered consecutively with the first text pages being page 1 (i.e. not title page or outline).
- Please use the title page template available for download on the chair's website.
- The importance of linguistic, grammatical and orthographic correctness of the seminar paper should be borne in mind. In case a paper abounds in grammatical and orthographical mistakes, the overall impression of it becomes negative, even though the content might be correct.

TimeLine

COMP 495 – Seminar Paper is a student driven exercise therefore ensure you adhere to the following timelines.

Start	End	Milestone
1st February 2026	3rd March 2026	Approval of Research Title/Topic by the Instructor
3rd March 2026	31st March 2026	Writing the Seminar Paper
31st March 2026		Mini Presentation to access progress
20 – 30 April 2026		Final Defence